



Cloud of uncertainty: Despite India never playing in the FIFA World Cup, the spectacle has always taken centre stage among football fans. But 2026 carries a different writing on the wall. AFP & GETTY IMAGES

from India in terms of audience appetite, advertisers, and overall media ecosystem.”

“One significant factor is match timing; fixtures scheduled at late-night or early-morning hours for Indian audiences can materially impact viewership peaks, which in turn affects advertising inventory and revenue potential. Even marquee events can struggle to deliver optimal returns when they fall outside prime viewing windows,” he adds.

The FIFA World Cup 2026 is being played in the United States of America, Canada and Mexico, placing most matches outside prime Indian viewing hours.

Of the 104 games in the World Cup this time, only 14 begin before midnight. In comparison, Qatar 2022 had 44 of its 64 matches before midnight, while Russia 2018 had 63.

Profitability the only priority

“The business scenario in sports in India has shifted primarily to profitability,” a source from one of the broadcasters says.

“Subscription is a limited option in this country, despite the appetite being there. In the West, football is mostly behind paywalls. You cannot do that in India.”

Sky Sports charges a subscription fee of about £22 per month to show the Premier League in the UK, while FOX Sports, the World Cup broadcaster in the US, sells its FOX One + ESPN Bundle for \$40 per month.

The FIFA World Cup 2022 was streamed on JioCinema and Sports18HD, with the former offering it for free and the latter charging Rs. 12 for the channel. The result: India saw one of the steepest individual market drops, losing 87 million linear viewers in four years. The audience moved to digital, which was free, not away from football. Meanwhile, JioStar reportedly lost millions with the free-to-air service.

In general, though, football viewership in the country has declined. The Indian Super League, the top flight of men’s football, has seen its broadcast rights valuation fall by 97 per cent in the last year.